

Photographs by K.M. KISHAN



Unsafe Ride

■ Over 20,000 cognisable offences have been committed on moving trains in Bihar since 2000.

■ In 2007, Bihar accounted for almost 11 per cent of crimes reported by the railway police across India.

■ More than seven crimes take place everyday on trains passing through Bihar.

■ The GRP in Bihar was last strengthened in 1996. Currently, one GRP personnel has to police more than one kilometre of track everyday.

PASSENGERS WHO WERE ROBBED IN A MOVING TRAIN NEAR BUXAR PROTEST AT PATNA JUNCTION

"The GRP in Bihar needs to triple its current manpower."

A.S. NIMBRAN
ADG, RAILWAY POLICE

night and with the added burden, we can hardly do anything with this manpower. We escort the few trains we feel are vulnerable and leave others unescorted," says a GRP official. Besides, dacoits usually operate in teams of about 20 members, so a five-man escort party, equipped with .303 bolt action rifles, is often ineffective.

Additional Director General of Police (Railways) A.S. Nimbran admits that the GRP in Bihar needs at least three times the number of currently available strength of 3,149 personnel. At current status, one GRP man has to alone cover more than one kilometre of track everyday. Way back in 1985, the Railway Norms Committee had recommended recruitment of at least 8,000 constables. More than two decades later, the strength is still less than half of what was prescribed.

According to officials, increasing the GRP's strength is always a tough call because both the state and the Central governments have to agree to share their salary and other recurring expenditure. Ironically, several railway ministers hailing from Bihar have actually made things worse. Since 1996—when the GRP was last upgraded—all railway ministers from Bihar had their political rivals ruling their home state. During their respective stints as railway minister, Ram Vilas Paswan and Nitish Kumar had to face a RJD government in Bihar. Similarly, Lalu holding the reins of the Railway Ministry has had to face his bête noire Nitish Kumar running Bihar. "Since the GRP is controlled by the state government, railway ministers have refused to share the plan expenditure costs, perhaps fearing

that this may allow a political rival in the state (who may hold a recruitment drive for constables and claim credit for this) earn brownie points," says a senior police officer.

Containing railway crime also requires superior coordination between the GRP, district police and Railway Protection Force (RPF)—which does not happen at the ground level. While railway authorities blame the state's poor law and order situation for these incidents, state officials put the onus on railway authorities to ensure the safety of passengers. The RPF says crimes committed inside trains do not concern them. The dacoits are outside the jurisdiction of the GRP once they get off the train, and this is where the district police have to chip in. This, however, rarely happens.

Obviously, the turnaround story scripted by Lalu perhaps does not really have security as one of its components. Till that figures in the ministry's list of priorities, train travel through Bihar will remain dangerous. ■